### *The Soviet Stance*

As India's relations with China deteriorated, its interest in the state of Sino-Soviet relations increased. Officials tried to detect whether there were disagreements between Beijing and Moscow.[110] After 1958, it was clear to them that there were some differences because of Beijing's greater orthodoxy, but they believed that the Chinese need for aid and the Soviet need for bloc unity would prevent a breakup. Thus India was careful not to overestimate the likelihood of a split.

When the boundary dispute was first made public in September 1959, Moscow called for China and India to solve the problem peacefully. Soviet neutrality rather than outright support for ally China surprised Indian officials, who speculated about the cause and the extent of that stance.[111] Nehru believed that the Soviet Union, concerned about growing Chinese strength, saw India as "a balancing force in relation to China in Asia." Moreover, Moscow would not want to see Beijing push India into the West's arms.[112]

Allen Dulles shared the view that an "anxious" Moscow would want the dispute settled as soon as possible. Chinese policymakers, however, were annoyed about Soviet criticism of their economic approach and concerned about the impact that backing down on an international issue would have on their domestic credibility. Thus he did not think that Beijing would heed Moscow's advice.[113] The State Department policy planning director indeed saw continuing Sino-Indian tension as a sign that Beijing would now resist Moscow on foreign policy at times.[114] But while State and CIA intelligence analysts agreed that evidence of "critical strains" between Beijing and Moscow was mounting, like Indian officials, they, too, did not expect a "serious weakening of the alliance."[115]

Indian officials similarly did not believe that Moscow could restrain Beijing, but they hoped that, at the very least, it would remain neutral. For this reason, they had avoided internationalizing the Tibet issue, limited overt cooperation with the US on Sino-Indian questions, and looked askance at Indian press criticism of the Soviet stance.[116] When Khrushchev visited India in early 1960, he told the prime minister that he would continue to try to take "no definite stand." Moscow, he said, did not want its relations with either Delhi or Beijing to "cool off."[117] Nehru subsequently